

Part Two

Zu Weiyun caught up with Heka and Baoyu before long.

Returning Starburst was only part of the reason she had come. Their individual investigations had all led them toward the same conclusion, and it quickly became apparent that they would accomplish far more together than apart. Their goals did not merely align—they fit together so neatly that refusing to cooperate would have been foolish.

The moment Heka spotted her approaching, she let out an excited laugh and rushed forward.

"Wei!"

Before Weiyun could so much as offer a greeting, Heka threw both arms around her in an enthusiastic embrace. The hug was warm, sincere, and utterly without reservation. Moments later, Baoyu found himself being pulled into it as well.

With one arm slung over each of their shoulders, Heka grinned triumphantly.



"The so-called drowned ghost bride doesn't stand a chance against us!"

Weiyun couldn't help smiling.

"So," she asked, "what have you discovered?"

"Fraud and conspiracy!" Heka declared with theatrical enthusiasm.

Baoyu chuckled before elaborating.

"In short, we've found an abandoned network of tunnels beneath the hills surrounding the lake. Long ago they were likely used as emergency escape routes. They've been forgotten for years... which makes them perfect for someone looking to move goods unseen."

"And the ghost stories?" Weiyun asked.

"A distraction," Baoyu replied. "Someone has been encouraging rumors of hauntings to frighten people away from the area. Empty roads make excellent smuggling routes."

"We just haven't figured out who is behind it yet."

Weiyun nodded thoughtfully. "Then I arrived at just the right time."

In truth, another thought lingered quietly in the back of her mind.

Abandoned tunnels often held forgotten relics. Hidden caches. Lost heirlooms. Perhaps even treasures untouched for generations.

She tried to keep the thought from showing on her face.

She failed.

Heka leaned forward, eyes sparkling, "You've got that look."

"What look?" Weiyun tried to turn away.

"The treasure look." Heka moved to keep looking at her.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

Baoyu laughed. "She's right. Your eyes lit up the moment I mentioned abandoned tunnels."

"They did not," Wei protested.

"They absolutely did," Heka agreed cheerfully. "And it's adorable."

A faint blush crept across Weiyun's face. "I simply appreciate historical artifacts."

"Mhm."

"And objects of cultural significance."

"Mhm."

"And occasionally valuable antiques."

"There it is!" Heka laughed, pointing triumphantly. "I knew it!"

Rather than feeling embarrassed, Weiyun found herself smiling despite herself. "There is nothing wrong with appreciating history."

"Not at all," Heka said, wrapping an arm around her shoulders once more. "We'll just have to make sure you don't wander off chasing shiny things while we're catching smugglers."

"I can multitask."

"Of course you can!"

Baoyu sighed dramatically.

"I fear I've just witnessed the birth of an extremely dangerous partnership."

That evening, after a full day spent mapping trails and discussing possibilities, the three abandoned strategy in favor of something far more important.

They opened two bottles of green ant wine.

Rain tapped softly against the inn's windows while warm lanternlight filled the room with a comforting amber glow.

For the first time since meeting, conversation drifted away from investigations and toward themselves.

Heka lounged comfortably across the floor, cup in hand, "I grew up an orphan." She said it as casually as someone mentioning the weather. "When I was little, I'd sneak into martial sect territory by climbing trees."

Baoyu laughed immediately. "You mean spying."

"I was observing."

"You were causing trouble."

"I was conducting research."

She ignored his amused expression.

"I desperately wanted to learn martial arts. I'd sit hidden in branches for hours watching everyone train."

"And eventually," Baoyu added, "Master GNS caught her."

"I was spooked by a bird!"

"You fell."

"I slipped."

"You screamed."

"I did not scream."

Baoyu raised an eyebrow.

"You absolutely screamed."

Heka pointed accusingly at him before continuing.

"Master caught me before I hit the ground." Her expression softened. "Instead of punishing me, she simply asked why I'd been watching. I told her I wanted to become someone who could protect people." A warm smile spread across her face. "She saw something worth believing in."

"And from that day onward," Baoyu said quietly, "she raised Heka as one of her own."

Heka nodded. "I wasn't alone anymore."

Silence settled comfortably over the room.

After another sip of wine, Weiyun spoke. "My childhood wasn't nearly so exciting."

She smiled faintly.

"I come from an ordinary family within the fox tribe. I always admired wandering heroes." She stared into her cup. "But I couldn't bring myself to leave my family behind."

"So instead I trained. Found a master. Protected my village. Then the neighbouring villages.

Eventually the entire region."

Baoyu nodded approvingly. "I heard stories."

Weiyun looked genuinely surprised. "You did?"

"You've developed quite the reputation."

She laughed softly. "Apparently not enough to stop me from getting distracted whenever someone whispers the word 'treasure.'"

Heka nearly spilled her wine laughing. "I knew it!"

"I've accepted that I'll never live this down," Weiyun sighed dramatically.

"You absolutely won't," Heka replied.

There was another pause before Weiyun continued.

"I was married once."

Neither of the others interrupted.

"It wasn't a romance. The younger son of our tribe's patriarch asked for my help exposing his elder brother's crimes. Marriage allowed us to work together without attracting suspicion. We succeeded."

"And afterward?"

Weiyun smiled. "He knew my heart belonged to the jianghu. So he proposed another bargain. I would become his martial arts master. In exchange, he would continue protecting my family and our homeland while I finally pursued the life I'd always wanted."

Heka reached over and squeezed her hand. "He sounds like a good man."

"He is."

"And you're still friends?"

"We are."

"Good." Heka smiled. She believes with every part of herself that partings needn't be due to a failure or hurt. "I'm happy things ended kindly."

The sincerity in her voice erased any lingering awkwardness.

Baoyu quietly smiled into his cup.

The inn had only one remaining room available.

It contained one very large bed.

Weiyun immediately volunteered to sleep on a bedroll.

Heka looked positively scandalized.

"Absolutely not. There's more than enough room."

"I'll be fine."

"You don't have to suffer."

"We're perfectly capable of sharing."

Baoyu gently brushed a stray lock of Heka's hair back behind her ear. "Still too soon, dear."

"Oh." Heka nodded thoughtfully. "Right."

Weiyun busied herself arranging her blankets, desperately pretending she hadn't heard the implication. Heat rose steadily to her cheeks.

Neither Heka nor Baoyu seemed particularly embarrassed.

As the candles burned lower, conversation gradually faded into comfortable silence.

Just before the final flame was extinguished, Weiyun glanced toward the bed.

Heka met her eyes. She didn't speak. Only a smile.

Gentle.

Warm.

As though saying, *I'm glad you came. I'm glad you're here.*

Weiyun smiled back before lying down.

Outside, rain began to fall.

Morning arrived and the sky was hidden beneath thick gray clouds. The lake looked almost silver beneath the overcast sky.

Heka stood in the doorway of the inn, breathing in the cool air. "The kind of day smugglers love to see, I'd say," she announced happily.

She looked entirely too excited.

Weiyun folded her arms. "I don't think I've ever met someone quite so enthusiastic about exposing criminals."

Baoyu stepped beside her. "She's actually excited about something else."

Heka immediately looked away. "I'm excited about justice."

"Mhm."

"And perhaps..." A less mischievous yet equally worrying tone was now in Heka's voice. Baoyu smiled toward Weiyun. "...a surprise."

"A surprise? For me? Should I be worried?"

"You'll like it," Baoyu assured her. "Heka has an unusual talent."

"What kind?"

"Making people smile."

He glanced fondly toward Heka.

"More than once she's somehow discovered exactly what someone wanted before they even realized it themselves."

Heka rubbed the back of her neck, suddenly looking almost bashful. "I just pay attention."

Before Weiyun could ask anything further, Heka clapped her hands together.

"Come on! We've got villains to catch."

The roads around the lake were unusually quiet.

Most villagers had chosen to remain indoors before the weather worsened.

Their journey through the countryside was peaceful until they reached a field bordering the

forest.

An elderly farmer hurried to cover delicate crops before the coming rain.

Without hesitation, Heka broke into a jog.

"I'll help!"

She had barely reached the edge of the field before the farmer rounded on her.

His face twisted with anger.

"What are you doing here?"

"Get away from my land!"

"I don't need help from the likes of you!"

A string of increasingly unpleasant insults followed.

Weiyun saw it immediately. The subtle tightening of Heka's shoulders. The narrowing of her eyes. The slight shift of weight that always came before anyone had decided someone else deserved to be punched.

Without a word, Weiyun walked over. Bent slightly. Then unceremoniously lifted Heka cleanly over one shoulder.

Heka blinked. "...Eh?" Her feet dangled in the air.

The farmer continued shouting behind them as Weiyun calmly walked away.

Baoyu stared for a heartbeat before laughter escaped him. He followed after them, shaking his head.

Amazing, he thought. Someone else could read Heka as well as he could. Judging by the way things are progressing, he would no longer bear sole responsibility for preventing diplomatic incidents.

Once they were well out of earshot, Weiyun gently lowered Heka back onto the road.

Heka adjusted her robes. "Thanks."

Weiyun smiled, "You looked like you were about to punch him."

"I was considering it."

"But we don't have time for that today."

"No." Heka stretched before grinning sheepishly. "We don't." She looked toward Baoyu. "Nice having that responsibility shared, doesn't it?"

Baoyu simply bumped her shoulder with his own. "My shoulders appreciate the break for sure."

The three shared a laugh before continuing down the road together toward the lake, unaware that before the day was over, they would be one step closer to uncovering the truth behind the drowned ghost bride.